

‘Neeraj can win another Olympic medal; Sachin should chase consistency, not 90m’

The **man who shaped** Neeraj Chopra’s Olympic journey reflects on India’s javelin rise, Sachin Yadav’s growth, and the fine art of sustainable excellence.

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At his home in the small village of Oberschlettenbach, nestled in the mountains of southwest Germany, athletics isn’t the top priority right now for 76-year-old javelin coach Klaus Bartonietz. These days, his attention is on his potato harvest. Having planted them in spring, he’s now busy digging them up. “I was thinking I’d get 40 kilos, but I’ve got about 35 kilos. But it’s hard work to get them all out of the ground,” says the septuagenarian with a laugh.

In recent weeks, though, Klaus has been reaping another kind of harvest. He’s just returned from Tokyo, where he coached Keshorn Walcott to his first World Championships gold medal. It was Klaus’s second javelin world title,

coming two years after he guided Neeraj Chopra to gold at the Budapest Worlds.

A second world title doesn’t stir much excitement in Klaus. “Life goes on. Of course, I’m satisfied with the effort and the outcome. It’s been effective,” he says matter-of-factly.

For many, the sight of Klaus in the stands of Tokyo’s Olympic Stadium — wearing a cap and T-shirt in the red and black of Trinidad and Tobago — came as a surprise. The German had ended his six-year stint with Neeraj last year, a period in which the Indian star became Olympic champion in Tokyo, World silver medallist in 2022 (Oregon), World champion in 2023 (Budapest), and Olympic silver medallist again in Paris in 2024.

Klaus had said one reason for stepping away was age. Neeraj, too, had moved on, beginning a new

phase under world record holder Jan Zelezny.

Klaus admits he expected to spend his days tending to his garden when, late last year, he got a call from Walcott’s manager. “He asked me if I would be willing to work as a consultant for Keshorn. Initially, we were only talking over the phone, and I gave him some advice — about once a week, then once every couple of weeks in winter. He was mostly in the Caribbean, so there wasn’t any way to go there to train him. Then, at the end of April, it happened a couple of times. After that, he had a training camp in Portugal, and that’s when we came together in May,” he recalls.

Whatever they’re doing, it’s working. Walcott, who became the youngest Olympic men’s javelin champion when he won gold in 2012, threw a season’s best of 88.16m to